

The Political Economy of Policies for Smallholder Agriculture

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Summary. — As the experience of the 20th century has shown, implementing policies that increase agricultural productivity among smallholders is a particularly promising strategy to achieve pro-poor growth. However, history also reveals major political challenges to adopting this strategy. The paper compares the experience of Asian countries that were able to launch a smallholder-based Green Revolution with the experience of African countries that are still struggling with this goal. It then reviews the political economy literature to identify the factors that account for these divergent experiences. Finally, the paper develops a conceptual framework to guide empirical research to close the knowledge gaps identified by the review.

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1. INTRODUCTION

More than 100 years ago, Karl Kautsky published “The Agrarian Question” (Kautsky, 1899). The question he analyzed remains important today: is there a need and justification for agricultural policies that specifically support smallholder agriculture? Kautsky argued that the peasant producers persisted due to self-exploitation and underconsumption, which were not deemed to be socially desirable situations. Kautsky was convinced of the technical superiority of large farms and saw no justification for agricultural policies designed to support small farmers.¹ The experience of the 20th century tells a different story; implementing policies to support the economic development of small farmers has proven to be a particularly successful strategy to reduce rural poverty and to use agriculture as an engine of growth on the road to industrialization (Mellor, 1976). Both Western industrialized countries and the fast-growing Asian economies document the success of this development strategy. As Lipton (2005) notes, there is virtually no example of mass poverty reduction in modern history that did not start with sharp increases in employment and self-employment income due to increased productivity among small family farms.

Nevertheless, the experience of the 20th century has also shown that it is a major challenge to implement agricultural policies that support small farmers in ways that lead to poverty reduction and economic development. While most African and Asian countries initially neglected agriculture after achieving their independence, several Asian countries changed their strategies and started to promote a smallholder-based agricultural intensification, which led to the Green Revolution. Why did they decide at some point in time to embark on this strategy? And why have so few African countries chosen a similar strategy? What is the political rationale behind this phenomenon? And what is the potential for change?

Understanding the political economy of policies that support smallholder agriculture is important, as more than 90% of the world's 1.1 billion poor live on small family farms (Lipton, 2005). While the future of smallholders remains

debated, there is substantial evidence that the contribution of agriculture to growth and poverty reduction will continue to depend on the broad participation of smallholder farmers (Diao, Hazell, Resnick, & Thurlow, 2007; Lipton, 2005; World Bank, 2007). This evidence is supported both by studies that analyze past experiences and by simulation models (Dorward *et al.*, 2004). The rationale for public policies that support small farmers is based on the insight that they are affected by a variety of market failures. These arise due to the non-excludability of many agricultural technologies, coordination challenges that prevent exploiting economies of scale, information asymmetries, a lack of assets that can serve as collateral, and the vulnerability of smallholders to the biological, climatic, and market risks inherent in agricultural production (Binswanger & McIntire, 1987; Kydd & Dorward, 2004; Petit, 1995; Scandizzo, Hazell, & Anderson, 1984; Schmitt, 1991). While the actual extent of such market failures remains debated, it is now widely acknowledged that they are particularly relevant in early phases of agricultural development and that public policies are required to address them (Dorward *et al.*, 2004; World Bank, 2007).

Against this background, this paper reviews the available evidence on the changing patterns of agricultural policies that affect smallholder agriculture, focusing on a comparison between Africa and Asia. The paper also reviews approaches that have been developed in economics and political science to explain agricultural policy choices. The review shows that existing political economy models are better able to explain why inefficient agricultural policies persist than to explain why and when countries are able to change their agricultural

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policies in favor of smallholder agriculture. The paper argues that empirical case studies will be a useful first step to closing existing knowledge gaps regarding the political economy of smallholder-oriented policies, and it develops a conceptual framework for this purpose.

2. POLICIES FOR SMALLHOLDER AGRICULTURE IN AFRICA AND ASIA

To review the changing patterns of agricultural policies, it is useful to distinguish between two periods: the pre-structural adjustment period and the structural adjustment and post-structural adjustment period. Even though there are time differences across countries, most African countries adopted structural adjustment policies during 1985–95 (Friis-Hansen, 2000). In Asian countries, the adoption of structural adjustment policies has been more diverse. Still, distinguishing these two time periods appears useful, as many Asian countries launched their Green Revolution before the mid-1980s.

(a) *The pre-structural adjustment period*

One of the major studies of agricultural policies in the pre-structural adjustment period is the comparative analysis by Krueger, Schiff, and Valdés (1991) which included 18 countries and covered the period during 1960–85. This study confirms earlier research that establishes that low-income countries tend to discriminate against agriculture, while high-income countries tend to protect this sector (see Anderson & Hayami, 1986, and the literature quoted there). The study also shows that the indirect tax on agriculture from macroeconomic policies, such as overvalued exchange rates, was three times the direct tax on agriculture, such as export taxes. Of the countries covered in the study, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, and Zambia had the highest degree of discrimination against agriculture, with an average total nominal protection rate of –52. Of the 18 countries included, only Korea and Portugal had policies that were favorable to agriculture, with mildly positive protection rates. The average rate of economic growth in these two countries was double that of the three countries with the highest discrimination against agriculture. In the other countries included in the study, protection rates varied from –44 to –8. The study uncovered another important trend: export crops tended to be discriminated against, while import-competing crops were often protected.

Bates (1981) illustrates these trends for the case of Africa. With regard to export crops, he finds that marketing boards may not only have protected producers from world price volatility but also provided the resources for investing in large-scale infrastructure and industrialization projects that were disproportionately concentrated in urban areas. Bates' (1981) study also shows that subsidized inputs and grain marketing boards were a common strategy in the pre-structural adjustment period to encourage high food production and low food prices. There were also important variations to this trend. If elites were involved in the production of a food crop, governments were less likely to use policies that depressed prices. In Malawi, smallholders continued to face legal restrictions in growing cash crops even after the country's independence. Growing cash crops was the privilege of the owners of large-scale estates, including the country's president and the leading members of his party (Orr, 2000).

Several authors have pointed out that in many African countries, public support for agricultural production has supported clientelistic networks of the state, even though such

support was often implemented under the pretext of “fair treatment” in the form of pan-seasonal and pan-territorial pricing for inputs and produce (Holmen, 2005). Efforts to improve agriculture often benefited politically influential people and political supporters, including retired civil servants and soldiers, who did not necessarily have any background in farming. At the same time, subsidized inputs, credit, and extension largely bypassed small farmers (Holmen, 2005; van de Walle, 2001). Setting up capital-intensive mechanized state farms was also a common approach. Nigeria, for example, established large-scale state-run companies in the mid-1970s to produce grains, roots, sugar, and livestock. None of these farms ever became profitable (Akande, 2005), which resembled the experience of similar approaches in other African countries (Bates, 1981).

Just as the African countries, many Asian countries also adopted policies that depressed food prices in the early periods following their independence. However, in the mid-1960s, the three “early Green Revolution” countries—India, Indonesia, and the Philippines—abandoned low-price policies for food grains and implemented agricultural policies that were focused on increasing the productivity of small farms. In addition to exploiting a major breakthrough in plant breeding, the success of the Green Revolution was based on a combination of policies that addressed the market failures confronting smallholders. These policies included public investment in agricultural research, extension and irrigation infrastructure, subsidized access to inputs, and agricultural credit as well as price guarantees. This policy shift occurred simultaneously in India, Indonesia, and the Philippines but apparently did so without any direct connection between them. In fact, the political circumstances in which the Green Revolution occurred were country specific, even though food shortages were central in each of the three cases (Djurfeldt & Jirström, 2005). In India, the goal of reaching food self-sufficiency emerged as a major condition to remain politically independent after the United States decided to use food exports as an instrument of foreign policy (Subramaniam, 1995). In Indonesia, the political and economic crisis caused by rice shortages in the mid-1960s, which coincided with a problematic world rice market situation, stimulated a shift in food price policies in favor of rice producers. In the Philippines, a similar policy shift also followed serious rice shortages, which were associated with a change in government (Djurfeldt & Jirström, 2005). Taiwan and Korea had already adopted smallholder-oriented policies of agricultural intensification. Reaching food self-sufficiency in food grains had become a major goal for them as well (Jirström, 2005). Later on, other Asian countries, including China, Malaysia, and Thailand, followed the strategy of smallholder-based agricultural intensification with impressive results in terms of growth and poverty reduction.

In spite of the frequent claim that the Green Revolution mainly benefited large farmers, empirical studies document that the Green Revolution technologies were scale-neutral and that they often benefited smallholders in particular (Akande, Djurfeldt, Holmen, & Isinika, 2005; Hazell & Ramasamy, 1991; Lipton, 1989). In the case of India, the explicit political focus on smallholders in launching the Green Revolution is well documented. The Minister of Agriculture who masterminded India's Green Revolution, Subramaniam, initially targeted larger progressive farmers in Punjab, but—according to his own account—this was a strategic choice to convince smallholders that the new technologies would work. His explicit goal was a smallholder-based agricultural intensification—a goal that he had to defend strongly against internal critics and against advisors from both the United States and

socialist countries. At that time, none of these groups trusted in the ability of smallholders to modernize (Subramaniam, 1995).

(b) *The structural adjustment and post-structural adjustment period*

One expected effect of the structural adjustment policies that were implemented from the mid-1980s onward was a reduction in the discrimination against the agricultural sector. According to a recent World Bank project led by Kym Anderson,² the anti-agricultural bias in developing countries has in fact declined, but this was often due to declines in the protection of manufacturing as much as due to declines in agricultural taxation. Some countries, especially in Asia, have moved from discrimination against their agricultural sectors toward protection. Moreover, the anti-trade bias in agricultural policies remains (Anderson, 2009).

With regard to Africa, the policy debate has focused on the question of whether structural adjustment has actually helped or hurt smallholder farmers. Two major positions have emerged in this debate. One position holds that the limited impact is due to the fact that liberalization policies have not been fully implemented or have been reversed, thus discouraging the entry of the private sector. The opposite position holds that agricultural development cannot take off under structural adjustment policies, as these policies leave the market failures that affect smallholder farmers unaddressed.

There is overwhelming empirical evidence that in many African countries, structural adjustment policies were in fact implemented only partly and that they have often been reversed (Cooksey, 2003; Jayne, Govereh, Mwanaumo, Nyoro, & Chapoto, 2002; Pletcher, 2000; van de Walle, 2001). The political economy of these policy shifts and their implications for smallholders are complex. To understand them, it is useful to distinguish between food crops and export crops. As export crops were heavily taxed during the pre-structural adjustment period, one would expect that smallholders who grow export crops benefited most from structural adjustment policies. There is some evidence supporting this point. In Burkina Faso, for example, where cotton comprises almost 60% of total exports, cotton production increased steadily after the 1994 CFA devaluation. The cotton sector experienced a growth of 250% during 1994–2003. The state marketing board SOFITEX was able to shield smallholders from the considerable fluctuations in the world market prices of cotton that occurred during this period (Grimm & Günther, 2004). Ghana is another example. The government embarked on cocoa sector reforms in the mid-1980s. Reforms focused on a gradual increase of the producer price paid to the farmers. During the 1996–97 and 2004–05 seasons, the prices farmers received increased from 50% to more than 70% of the international price. In this period, cocoa production almost doubled (Quartey, 2007).

Both these dramatic increases in smallholder production occurred under partial liberalization. Efforts to privatize Burkina Faso's state marketing board SOFITEX did not begin until the first decade of the 21st century. In the case of Ghana, the state marketing board (COCOBOD) remained the single exporter of cocoa, even though private companies were licensed to buy cocoa from farmers. In the early 2000s, the government also reintroduced a program of "mass-spraying" cocoa farms against diseases and providing fertilizers on a loan basis (Quartey, 2007). In Uganda, the coffee sector was in fact liberalized, and the Coffee Marketing Board was dismantled in 1991. Consequently, coffee producers were able to benefit from the world price of coffee, which peaked during

the 1994–95 growing season. Households located in Uganda's coffee districts experienced more than a 50% decline in poverty during 1992–99 (Kappel, Lay, & Steiner, 2004). However, the plummeting of world coffee prices in 1998 played a direct role in the subsequent rise in rural poverty during 1999–2003, particularly in the coffee districts (Kappel *et al.*, 2004; Okidi, Ssewanyana, & Muhumuza, 2004).

In contrast to the export crop sector, the food sector was often protected in the pre-structural adjustment period (see above). Therefore, one cannot assume a general improvement of producer prices as a consequence of structural adjustment. In fact, out of 14 African countries studied by Townsend (1999), only Nigeria, Uganda, Zimbabwe, and Tanzania experienced substantial and sustained increases in producer prices for food crops. In the other countries, producer prices for food crops declined. There is considerable evidence that in many cases, structural adjustment policies in the food-crop sector have also been implemented only partially and that they have often been reversed as well. Malawi is a particularly interesting example for food-crop policies that took "U-turns and full circles" (Harrigan, 2003). Since the adoption of structural adjustment policies in the mid-1980s, the government has several times abolished input subsidies under donor pressure and then reintroduced them with the argument to avoid an emerging food crisis. Jayne *et al.* (2002) show that liberalization in maize output markets and fertilizer markets has also been reversed in several other African countries.

The debate about the impact of structural and post-structural adjustment policies on smallholders continues. Some authors have pointed out that similar to the experience of the pre-structural adjustment area, smallholders in Africa hardly benefited from the subsidies that were maintained or reintroduced, even though governments justified partial or reversed liberalization with the argument of supporting smallholders. A review quoted by Pletcher (2000) showed that in Zambia, only 13% and 8% of smallholders received credit in the 1993–94 and 1994–95 seasons, respectively. Pletcher (2000) also finds that maize output markets were liberalized more fully than input markets because economic interest groups benefited from maize liberalization while similar interests benefited from continued government interventions in input markets. Similarly, Jayne *et al.* (2002) argue that state officials who became large farmers or traders during the pre-structural adjustment period were able to resist reforms or to manipulate the reform process to gain new avenues for patronage. For Malawi, Harrigan (2003) points out that only the richest 25% of smallholders, who received credit, were able to benefit from improved maize technologies. She also concludes that "the transition to democracy has led the new democratic government to politicize the issues of food security, input and credit subsidies *via* renewed state interventionism" (Harrigan, 2002, p. 860). The introduction of input packages provided by the public extension service to farmers' groups on a loan basis in Uganda (MAAIF, 2005) may also be attributed to political pressures arising from the introduction of a multi-party system.

Since liberalization has been partial, one could argue that the question as to what would happen to smallholder agriculture under full liberalization remains open. However, it has become widely acknowledged that smallholder agriculture is subject to a range of market failures, which require supporting public policies. The structural and post-structural adjustment experience has added new insights to this debate. Dorward, Poole, Morrison, Kydd, and Urey (2003) and Kydd and Dorward (2004) show that even in a basically profitable supply chain, low-level equilibrium traps can be caused by

opportunistic behavior and by coordination risks, especially the risk that other players will not make complementary investments in the supply chain. Markets for food staples, which are particularly important for poor smallholders, are especially affected by this problem. Problems encountered in maintaining high-quality standards for export crops experienced after liberalization (Friis-Hansen, 2000) also support the coordination failure hypothesis. Against this background, the current debate focuses on “market-smart” interventions, which address market failures in a way that fosters—rather than undermines—the emergence of the private sector (Morris, Kelly, Kopicki, & Byerlee, 2007). Vouchers for fertilizers that are targeted at poor farmers are an example. Empirical research on how well such “market-smart” instruments work remains limited, however.

The debate on whether state intervention is necessary has also remained politically relevant for the Asian Green Revolution countries. These countries were also forced to adopt structural adjustment policies due to economic and financial crises, which occurred mostly during the 1990s. The case of India illustrates the political challenges of reforming agricultural policies in this group of countries. India adopted far-reaching liberalization policies after a financial crisis in 1991. In the agricultural sector, however, liberalization remained partial (Mooij, 2005). A study by Fan, Gulati, and Thorat (2008) shows that the returns created by fertilizer, power, and credit subsidies (in terms of agricultural GDP and poverty reduction) have declined considerably. For example, the return on fertilizer subsidies (Rs. per Rs. spent) declined from 2.41 in the 1960s to 0.53 in the 1990s. The authors conclude that the initial subsidies in credit, fertilizer, and irrigation have been crucial for small farmers to adopt new technologies but that they have become unproductive in the recent years. However, reducing such subsidies or moving toward targeted subsidies has proved difficult due to a range of factors, including an increasing income gap between the agricultural and non-agricultural sector, resulting in electoral pressures to reduce “agrarian distress.” Moreover, 40 years after the Green Revolution, the goal of food self-sufficiency had remained a prominent theme in the political discourse on agricultural policy in India (Birner, Gupta, & Sharma, 2010).

3. EXPLAINING AGRICULTURAL POLICY CHOICES

The previous section has highlighted the political challenges confronting policies that support smallholder agriculture. To identify the political factors that account for these challenges, this section briefly reviews the literature on the political economy of agricultural policy.

(a) *Interest groups and collective action*

Interest group approaches, also referred to as society-centered approaches in the political science literature, focus on differences in the ability of rural and urban groups of society to overcome the collective action problem of organizing themselves as political interest groups and to exercise political pressure (Olson, 1965). These approaches have been widely used in the agricultural economics literature to explain why developing countries tax agriculture and industrialized countries protect it (Binswanger & Deininger, 1997; de Gorter & Swinnen, 2002), and why there is urban bias (Lipton, 1977). Interest group approaches have also been dominant in the political science literature on agricultural policies in Africa, most notably in the work of Bates (1981).

These approaches provide several arguments for the political difficulty of implementing policies that promote smallholder agriculture (Binswanger & Deininger, 1997). As a large, spatially dispersed group with heterogeneous interests and limited access to education and communication and transportation infrastructure, small farmers in developing countries face numerous obstacles to engage in collective action and defend their interests. Their incentives to engage in political action are often limited by poverty, which results in short time horizons and risk aversion. Large farmers and other members of the rural elite are in a better position to overcome these obstacles and become effective political interest groups. Compared with small farmers, the urban population has several advantages in exercising political influence. The urban elite is typically close to policy-making circles, and due to spatial concentration, the urban poor are better able to exercise political pressure in the form of demonstrations and revolts than are small farmers. Interest group approaches also help to explain why industrialized countries tend to protect agriculture; as a small group, farmers in such countries are better able to organize than are consumers and can therefore more readily engage in rent seeking.

The interest group approach also suggests that small-scale farmers in the food-crop sector face particular difficulties in influencing agricultural policies, as these crops dominate production in the poorer and more remote areas, where the capacity for collective action is low. Smallholders in the export crop sector often have slightly better access to roads and output markets and a greater capacity for collective action around particular commodity-based organizations. The interest group approach also suggests that agricultural policies that provide private goods, such as subsidized credit and inputs, are more likely to be provided than public goods, such as roads (López & Galinato, 2006). Private goods can be individually appropriated by large-scale farmers who are politically more powerful, as they face fewer difficulties than do smallholders to form political interest groups. The political influence of larger farmers may also prevent the adoption of policy instruments that are targeted at smallholders. As indicated above, such instruments dominate the current agricultural policy debate. One needs to consider, however, that smallholders may also resist the move from price policies to targeted policy instruments if they have reasons to mistrust state agencies to implement targeted approaches appropriately (Birner *et al.*, 2010).

(b) *Interaction of voters and interest groups with politicians*

A second major group of approaches to explain agricultural policy choices focuses on the interaction of voters, or groups of voters, with politicians (politician–voter models or voter support models). These models assume that politicians choose policies that maximize their chances of staying in office, implying that political leadership is contested, either through democratic elections or otherwise. Using this approach, Anderson (1995) is able to show that the distributional effects of different agricultural policies can explain the pattern of agricultural protection in rich countries and agricultural taxation in poor countries without even taking into account the relative costs of collective action by different groups discussed above. Zusan (1976) provides the foundation for another group of explanatory models, which capture the political interaction between lobby groups and the government. The extensive literature that is based on these approaches has been reviewed by de Gorter and Swinnen (2002). McMillan and Masters (2000), by modeling the interaction between governments and agricultural producers, show that the characteristics of different agri-

cultural commodities (such as sunk costs) also help to explain the taxation of agriculture in tropical countries.

(c) *Type of political regime*

The explanatory approaches discussed above focus on the pressure that interest groups and voters can exercise to influence government behavior. As [van de Walle \(2001\)](#) argues, such society-centered approaches are hardly suitable to explain political choices in African countries, because most African regimes enjoy a considerable degree of autonomy from societal pressures. He proposes a state-centered framework to analyze policy choices in Africa. His framework assumes that African states are “neopatrimonial,” which implies that they combine “an external façade of a modern rational-legal administration with an internal patrimonial logic of dyadic exchange, prebendalism, and the private appropriation of public resources by state elites” ([van de Walle, 2001, p. 16](#)). He also argues that the new democratic regimes in Africa are governed by the same logic and that foreign aid has played an essential role in sustaining Africa’s neopatrimonial regimes. His concept has been widely used in the literature reviewed in Section 2(b) to explain why structural adjustment policies in the agricultural sector have been implemented only partially or have been reversed.

The relation between the type of political regime and agricultural policy choices has also been analyzed in the quantitative literature on the political economy of agricultural policy choices. This relation has been the focus of a class of models that explicitly capture interactions among politicians, for example, by modeling legislative bargaining under different constitutional rules ([Henning & Struve, 2006](#)). Studying the role of political institutions for agricultural policy choices, [Beghin and Kherallah \(1994\)](#) find that pluralistic systems are associated with higher agricultural protection levels, though in a nonlinear fashion. Civil liberties also matter according to their analysis, especially in developing countries. [Olper \(2001\)](#) finds that agricultural protection is highest in democracies with multi-party systems. [Thies and Schuyler \(2007\)](#) show that the specific features of a political system, such as federalism, party fragmentation, and electoral cycles, also matter for agricultural policy choices. Analyzing time-series data for Belgium, [Swinnen, Banerjee, and de Gorter \(2001\)](#) find that the introduction of democratic reforms was associated with an increase in agricultural protection. These findings support the argument that the reintroduction of input subsidies discussed in Section 2(b) may have been caused by the democratic pressures that many African countries experienced during the structural adjustment and post-structural adjustment periods.

(d) *Ideas and ideology*

Ideas and ideology are typically considered endogenous in the economics literature on agricultural policy choices, based on the assumption that ideas and ideologies are merely used to defend economic or political interests. As a result, few quantitative political economy models account for ideology ([de Gorter & Swinnen, 2002](#)). However, the qualitative literature suggests that ideas and ideologies play an important role in explaining agricultural policy choices. Policies in the pre-structural adjustment period that taxed agriculture in order to finance rapid industrialization have been influenced by the notion of “African socialism” and by dependency theory ([Krueger et al., 1991](#)). These policies were also supported by the mainstream economic thinking of the time, as emphasized by [Bates \(1981\)](#). The withdrawal of public sector intervention in agriculture in the structural adjustment period was obvi-

ously driven by a general paradigm shift in international development thinking ([Paarlberg & Grindle, 1991](#)). Likewise, the current discussion on agricultural policies that support smallholders, such as “market-smart subsidies,” is influenced by the “Post-Washington Consensus.” The idea of food self-sufficiency continues to play a dominant role in the agricultural policy discourse, both in Africa and in Asia.

The political orientation of a regime along the political spectrum from left to right can also be assumed to influence agricultural policy choices, especially in authoritarian regimes, where political decision makers have more autonomy. It is certainly no coincidence that authoritarian regimes with a strong development orientation, for example, China and Indonesia, were able to launch a Green Revolution, whereas authoritarian regimes without development orientation, such as Uganda under Idi Amin, were not. However, the ideological orientation of a political regime has largely been neglected in economic models of agricultural policy choices.

(e) *Social mobilization*

As discussed above, interest group models assume that smallholders face major difficulties in becoming organized as political interest groups. The history of peasant movements, however, indicates that they have been well able to overcome these difficulties through social mobilization, especially in Asia. In India, smallholders became organized during the time of the liberation struggle against the colonial regime. The All India Kisan Sabha (Peasant League) was founded in 1936, by uniting peasant leagues that had emerged in different states. In 1946, the movement had 800,000 members ([Yardumian, 1945](#)). In other Asian countries, smallholders became organized as part of the communist movement. The Chinese revolution was essentially a peasant revolution. Until today, it has remained the central tenet of Maoist ideology—and the guerilla movements inspired by it—that smallholder farmers and agricultural laborers will be the driving force of a revolution that will transform agrarian society. The “communist threat” has been suggested as one of the political factors that explains the emphasis on agricultural development in Southeast Asia ([Djurfeldt & Jirström, 2005](#)). The Indonesian Peasant Front BTI (Barisan Tani Indonesia) was created by the Indonesian Communist Party. Considered “one of the most spectacular peasant mobilizations in Asia,” the BTI had over 8.5 million members in 1964 ([Huizer, 1999, pp. 31, 32](#)). The movement was extinguished in the wave of agrarian violence that brought Suharto’s regime to power and killed more than half a million peasants ([Huizer, 1999](#)). However, the fact that smallholder farmers had demonstrated their ability to organize as a political force may well have been an important rationale behind the strong emphasis on smallholder agricultural development that characterized General Suharto’s rule. In view of these facts, it appears reasonable to assume that social mobilization among peasants in Asia and the absence of comparable movements in Africa are among the factors that explain why Asia launched a Green Revolution and Africa did not. This explanation is not inconsistent with interest group theory, as smallholders in Asia faced lower transaction costs of collective action due to higher population densities and the prevalence of irrigated agriculture, which requires collective action.

4. KNOWLEDGE GAPS

In spite of the comprehensive quantitative and qualitative literature on the political economy of agricultural policy mak-

ing, important knowledge gaps regarding the political economy of policies for smallholder agriculture remain.

(a) *Role of smallholders*

In the political economy models reviewed above, agricultural producers are often considered one group or are disaggregated by the commodities they produce. This may be related to the strong focus of this literature on agricultural protection and the inefficiency created by it. The literature on the choice of specific policy instruments is dominated by concerns about inefficient policy choices and rent seeking (see the review by *de Gorter and Swinnen (2002)*). While this focus is certainly justified, the political economy of policy instruments that specifically aim to overcome the market failures faced by smallholders in developing countries has received rather limited attention so far.

(b) *Explaining policy change*

The quantitative literature reviewed above has been remarkably successful in explaining the general patterns of agricultural policies and the distortions to agricultural incentives that they create. In particular, the shift from the taxation of agriculture in low-income economies to agricultural protection in high-income economies is well explained by existing political economy models. The quantitative political economy literature has been far less successful, however, in explaining why and under which conditions policy changes that reduce distortions to agricultural incentives occur. One reason for this knowledge gap is the “as-if” nature of the political-economy models. In essence, these models explain policy outcomes “as-if” politicians and interest groups behave as assumed in these models. This approach is related to the problem of “observational equivalence” (*de Gorter & Swinnen, 2002*). The same outcomes can often be explained by different models. Recommendations for policy change are obviously problematic if it remains unclear to what extent model assumptions correspond to actual behavior. Even if only one model can explain a certain policy outcome, there is still a need to verify its behavioral assumptions in order to derive valid recommendations for policy change. Empirical research is needed to identify, for example, how lobbying behavior in agriculture works in practice, how much autonomy politicians have, and which historical factors and specifics of the political system that are not captured in the respective models influence political outcomes. Such research is mostly limited to industrialized countries. Empirical studies of the interaction between agricultural lobby groups and politicians, for example, have focused on the role of campaign contributions by agricultural lobby groups in the USA (see the review by *de Gorter and Swinnen (2002)*). An exception is the study of agricultural lobbying networks in the European Union by *Henning and Pappi (1999)*. For developing countries, comparable studies of agricultural policy-making processes and the way in which interest groups actually interact with policy makers remain limited.

There is also a tendency in the agricultural economics literature to take the success of a model in explaining observed outcomes as proof that the assumption of self-interested behavior is accurate. For example, the notion that politicians and voters can be motivated by social concerns (*Baldwin, 1989*) is rejected as “myth” only because models assuming self-interested behavior can explain the same outcomes (*de Gorter & Swinnen, 2002*). While a healthy skepticism of the motivations that drive politicians is certainly justified, this ap-

proach neglects the substantial empirical literature on the management of policy reforms, which shows that changes in policy often occur because policy makers have goals that cannot be reduced to self-interest or positional games (*Grindle & Thomas, 1989*). Some political economy models integrate ideology, as mentioned above, but it appears that the role of ideas has been more prevalent in explaining why inefficient policies exist (*Goldstein & Keohane, 1993*) than in explaining why policy change happens. As *Binswanger and Deininger (1997, p. 1999)* note, “the impacts of ideas as generators and facilitators of policy change” represent “one of the areas where our knowledge is still very limited and poorly integrated across subfields and schools of social science.” As political economy models leave little room for the ability of politicians to bring about policy change, they predict that a shift toward more efficient and equitable policies requires “reforms of existing political constraints . . . , such as electoral rules, legislation governing political resource contribution, subsidization of information and organization costs of less influential groups, constitutional constraints on government activities like the budgetary process, and other similar institutional reforms” (*de Gorter & Swinnen, 2002, p. 1923*). With the exception of reducing the information and organization costs of less influential groups, such general reforms of the political system are challenging, and pursuing them as a strategy to bring about agricultural policy change seems far-fetched.

(c) *The role of recent developments*

Knowledge gaps exist not only with regard to the strategies that can bring about policy change in favor of smallholder agriculture but also with regard to the roles that recent developments play in this respect. This section highlights some of these developments.

(i) *Changes in the global food system*

International agribusiness enterprises have become the dominant players in agricultural value chains, and this trend has become increasingly relevant for developing countries. Input markets are already dominated by a small number of multinational enterprises, food processing firms are integrating backward into primary production and forward into retailing, and retailing is being transformed by the “supermarket revolution” (*World Bank, 2007*). There is a burgeoning literature on the effects of these changes on smallholders and their prospects of integrating into new value chains.³ However, the role of these agribusiness enterprises as political actors in developing countries and their influence on policies with regard to smallholder agriculture are not well understood.

(ii) *Climate change and bioenergy*

Rising energy prices and concerns about climate change have stimulated the use of biofuels, which in turn has contributed to the recent surge in the prices of major agricultural commodities. The implications of these trends for smallholder-oriented agriculture in developing countries are ambiguous. On the one hand, the production of biofuels creates new opportunities for smallholders; on the other, it may induce multinational companies to engage in the primary production of bioenergy crops that have economies of scale, resulting in a competition for land now cultivated by smallholders. The impact of these important trends on the political economy of smallholder-oriented agriculture is one of the big questions for future research.

(iii) *Decentralization and regionalization*

Some three quarters of Sub-Saharan African countries have pursued some political decentralization during the past decades (Work, 2002). The implications for smallholder-oriented policies are ambiguous. Decentralization will provide more political space for farmers, at least if the capture of resources by the local elite can be controlled. However, empirical research suggests that agriculture has low priority in local governments as long as other basic needs, such as water supply, health, and education, are not met (Faguet, 2004). In parallel to the decentralization trend, there is also a trend toward regional integration. In West Africa, for example, both of the two major regional organizations ECOWAS (Economic Community of West African States) and WAEMU (West African Economic and Monetary Union) have regional agricultural policies, and both are influenced by the continent-wide Comprehensive Africa Agricultural Development Program (CAADP).

(iv) *The rise of farmers' organizations and civil society*

Though non-governmental organizations are not a new phenomenon, they have become increasingly active in agricultural policy making and play an advocacy role for smallholder-oriented policies at both the international and the national level. Oxfam is a prominent example. Empirical research on how they influence agricultural policy outcomes is scarce. The same applies to the emerging role of farmers' organizations in Africa. Available evidence indicates that they play a strong role in agricultural policy formulation in some countries, for example, Senegal (Resnick & Birner, 2009), but less in others, for example, Ghana (de Grassi, 2007). Reflecting the trend toward regional policy making, there are now also regional federations of farmer organizations, for example, in West Africa.

(v) *Participatory policy-making and evidence-based policy*

Promoted by Poverty Reduction Strategy Papers (PRSPs), policy processes are in many countries being increasingly con-

ducted in a participatory manner, involving stakeholder consultations. This is also the case for agricultural policy formulation. The rise of participatory policy making has increased the political space for smallholder organizations, but there are knowledge gaps regarding their ability to use this space. Donor agencies are also arguing for a shift toward "evidence-based policy-making," emphasizing the use of research-based knowledge in the policy process. However, there are still comparatively few empirical studies on the use of research-based knowledge in agricultural policy making, and there has been limited recognition that the use of such knowledge is in itself a question of political economy (de Grassi, 2007).

5. A CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

In view of these knowledge gaps, there is a need for more empirical research that will make it possible to understand when and how policy change in support of smallholder-based agriculture is possible. Ideally, this research would be informed by past experience, capture recent developments, and draw on the theoretical and empirical political economy literature reviewed above. One promising research strategy is the combination of qualitative case studies with quantitative modeling in such a way that each informs the other. Case studies can help to discover how policy change actually occurs and to identify the factors that influence processes of change. These factors can subsequently be integrated in quantitative political economy models of policy change. This section proposes a conceptual framework to guide such case studies.

The framework presented in Figure 1 combines two concepts that have been developed in the literature on policy change: (1) the Advocacy Coalition Framework by Sabatier and Jenkins-Smith (1993), which focuses on the role of ideas, policy beliefs, and research-based knowledge and (2) the concept of political capital, which has been used in political sci-

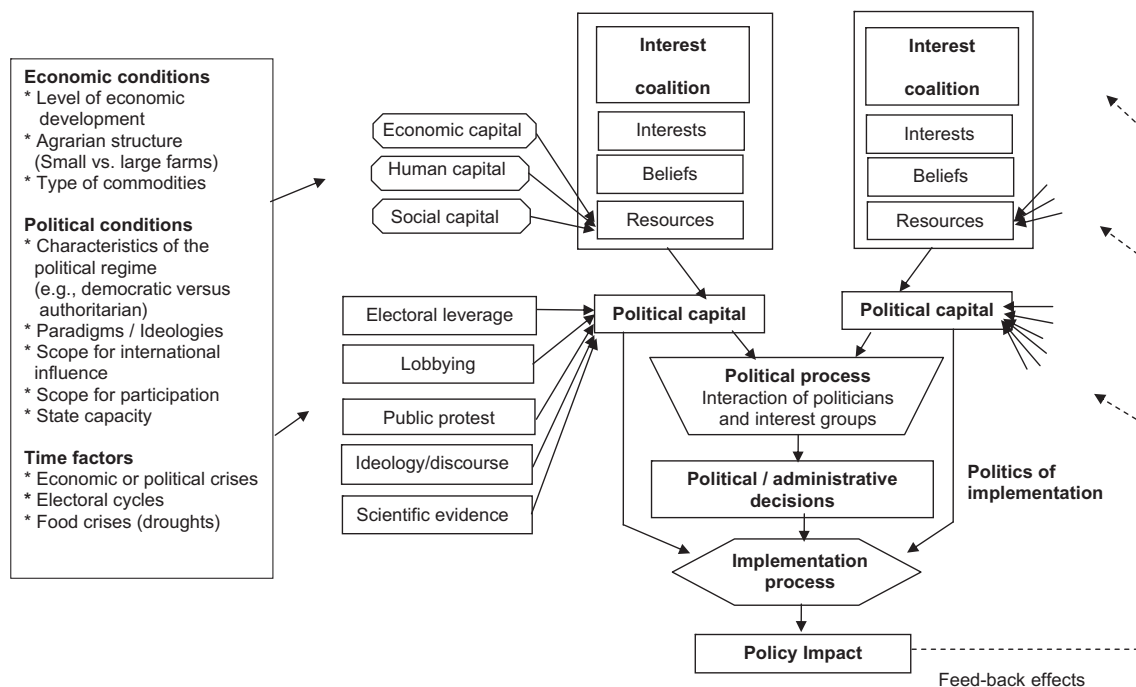


Figure 1. Conceptual framework for analyzing agricultural policy processes. Source: Adapted from Sabatier and Jenkins-Smith (1999) and Birner and Wittmer (2003).

ence to combine state-centered, society-centered, and political conflict theories in explaining policy choices (Hicks & Misra, 1993; Ilchman & Uphoff, 1998). The framework is informed by empirical case studies that apply these concepts to the political economy of agricultural and natural resource policies in Thailand, Indonesia, and India (Birner *et al.*, 2010; Birner & Wittmer, 2003; Rosyadi, Birner, & Zeller, 2005). The framework includes the four key elements of the framework used by de Gorter and Swinnen (2002) in their review of agricultural policy models: individual preferences of the citizenry, collective action by lobby groups, preferences of politicians, and political institutions.

As can be seen in Figure 1, the framework distinguishes different “interest coalitions,” which are groups of political actors that share common interests as well as common beliefs with regard to agricultural policies. One can often observe the formation of coalitions around two or three competing policy options (Sabatier & Jenkins-Smith, 1999). As highlighted by the Advocacy Coalition Framework, such coalitions may include not only economic interest groups but also members of the bureaucracy, legislators, civil society groups, applied researchers, and journalists. Using the concept of interest coalitions makes it possible to identify how various actors, including NGOs, emerging private-sector enterprises, multinational enterprises, and donor agencies, influence policies. In the case of agricultural policies, one can often observe a coalition in favor of interventions such as price support and input subsidies, as well as a coalition that is against such policies and favors liberalization. With regard to smallholder agriculture, the key question is whether a coalition emerges in support of the policies that actually reach and support small farms.⁴

The political economy models reviewed above capture the ways in which the interests and the resources of different groups are influenced by socioeconomic conditions, such as the level of economic development and the type of commodity produced. With regard to smallholders, the agrarian structure, especially the distribution of farm sizes, is of particular interest. The framework indicates that it is useful to consider how these conditions influence different types of resources that interest coalitions deploy, including their financial resources, their human capital, and their social capital (Figure 1). The concept of social capital refers to the capacity of interest groups to act collectively, an important factor highlighted in the interest group literature.

In addition to considering material interests and resources, the framework acknowledges that the beliefs held by the members of different interest coalitions matter as well. Sabatier and Jenkins-Smith (1993) distinguish between three types of beliefs: core beliefs, policy beliefs, and secondary beliefs. Core beliefs relate to fundamental values, such as the role of equity as compared to other goals. Like religious beliefs, core beliefs rarely change. Policy beliefs are related to the policy solutions that actors consider appropriate to realize their values. As the above review shows, important policy beliefs with regard to agricultural policies refer to the roles of subsidies, the private sector in promoting agricultural development, and of food self-sufficiency. Secondary beliefs refer to the way in which a particular policy is implemented. Secondary beliefs are more likely to change than core or policy beliefs. An example is the holding of different views on appropriate strategies to target subsidies to smallholders.

To understand how different interest coalitions can influence the policy process, the framework proposed here uses the concept of “political capital,” which can be defined as the resources that interest coalitions can use to realize outcomes

that are in their interest and correspond to their beliefs (*cf.* Birner & Wittmer, 2003). This concept draws on different political resource theories in economics and political science, including the work by Ilchman and Uphoff (1998), as well as on resource mobilization theory. This theory deals with the emergence, dynamics, and tactics of social movement organizations and examines the critical role that the mobilization of resources, for example, discretionary time and money of potential supporters, plays for the emergence and the success of social movements (McCarthy & Zald, 1977).

Strategies to create political capital include the two mechanisms highlighted in the political economy models reviewed above: electoral leverage and lobbying. In addition, the framework captures a range of other strategies that interest coalitions can use to create political capital. For example, they can also use public protest and stage demonstrations to pursue their political demands. The right strategy to create political capital depends on the types of resources that coalitions can mobilize and on the political context. Voting obviously can only be used in a functioning democracy. Lobbying works well if coalition members have financial resources and/or social capital in the form of membership in social elites that grants them access to political circles. Public protest, in contrast, requires social capital in the form of membership networks that can be mobilized for public action (Birner & Wittmer, 2003).

Interest coalitions can also use “ideological” arguments in public discourse, which is another strategy to create political capital. For example, interest coalitions in favor of smallholders may appeal to egalitarian ideologies. Attempting to change prevailing paradigms is also an important strategy. Interest coalitions in favor of smallholder-oriented policies in Africa may still need to change a prevailing paradigm among policy elites that smallholders resist modernization. The use of scientific evidence can be a helpful strategy in this respect. Sabatier and Jenkins-Smith (1993) develop a set of hypotheses regarding the factors that influence the use of research-based knowledge in the policy process. These include, for example, the level of conflict in core beliefs between different coalitions and the analytical tractability of the problem at stake.

The political capital stocks created by different interest coalitions will influence the political process, that is, the interactions of political decision makers with one another and with interest coalitions and voters. The nature of the political process is obviously influenced by the political conditions. According to the above review, important factors to be considered include the following: characteristics of the political regime (*i.e.*, position in the spectrum between democratic *vs* authoritarian; parliamentary *vs* presidential, one-party *vs* multi-party, federal *vs* unitary, centralized *vs* decentralized); civil liberties; political ideologies and paradigms; scope for regional and international influence; and scope for participatory policy making.

As indicated in Figure 1, the framework captures both the politics of decision making and the politics of implementation. Including an analysis of the political economy of policy implementation is important because policies often fail in the implementation stage (Thomas & Grindle, 1990). Interest coalitions that lost out in the political decision process can often undermine policy implementation. The debate on the implementation of structural adjustment policies reviewed in Section 2(b) underlines the need for studying the politics of implementing agricultural policies. Studying the implementation is also important because agricultural policies often require considerable state capacity for their effective implementation, and there is often a mismatch between policy choice and implementation capacity. Therefore, as indicated in Figure 1, state

capacity is also an important political factor to be considered in this framework.

The feedback arrows in Figure 1 indicate that the framework can be applied using a dynamic perspective. The impact of a policy can influence future policy choices in various ways, for example, by altering the resources available to actors and by changing their policy beliefs. Figure 1 also indicates that timing also matters for policy change. The literature on “windows of opportunity” can be applied to study this dimension of policy change (Kingdon, 1984). As indicated by the literature reviewed above, economic and financial crises as well as food shortages have played an important role in triggering agricultural policy change.

6. CONCLUDING REMARKS

The 20th century has generated a rich and diverse experience regarding the role of small farms in poverty reduction and economic development. The experience has shown that policies that support small farms by correcting for the market failures inherent in smallholder agriculture, especially in the early phases of agricultural development, are a particularly promising strategy to achieve pro-poor growth. The empirical evidence also shows that it is politically difficult to implement such policies. The review of the literature on the political economy of agricultural policies shows that current explanatory approaches offer numerous explanations of why inefficient policies persist, but they are hardly able to explain

why and how policy changes that lead to pro-poor agricultural growth happen. Likewise, there are knowledge gaps in the influence of new developments, such as the transformation of global value chains, the increasing demand for bioenergy, the emergence of farmers’ organizations in Africa, decentralization, regionalization, and the rise of participatory policy making, on the political economy of smallholder-oriented politics. Closing these knowledge gaps is important to enable countries, especially in Africa, to use agriculture more successfully for development than they had in the past. The paper argues that case studies will be useful to close prevailing knowledge gaps and to inform future quantitative modeling approaches. The paper has presented a conceptual framework to guide such case studies. More research on the political economy of smallholder-oriented politics is timely because after years of neglect, agriculture has re-appeared on the international development agenda. This is indicated, for example, by the World Development Report 2008 on “Agriculture for Development” (World Bank, 2007), and by the high-level efforts to promote a Green Revolution in Africa.⁵ Reviewing the experience of the 20th century, this paper has highlighted the political economy challenges that countries need to overcome if they want to launch a smallholder-based agricultural revolution and thereby use agriculture as an engine of pro-poor growth. However, as the paper also shows, there is reason to hope that these challenges can be overcome so that the futures of small farms, especially in Africa, will be brighter than their troubled pasts.

NOTES

1. Karl Kautsky, the leading theorist of the German Social Democrat Party (SPD) at the time, debated this question because the southern branch of the SPD demanded the inclusion of agricultural policies to support smallholder agriculture in the party’s program to attract the political support of small farmers and rural laborers. Unlike Lenin, Kautsky came to the conclusion that the peasantry may well persist in a capitalist system. However, he did not consider the peasantry a progressive force that could play an active role in the envisaged socialist revolution.

2. See www.worldbank.org/agdistortions for information on this project.

3. See, for example, the research conducted under the “Regoverning Markets” project at www.regoverningmarkets.org.

4. Sabatier and Jenkins-Smith (1993) define Advocacy Coalitions as groups that engage in a nontrivial degree of coordinated activity over time to pursue a certain policy option. The framework presented in this paper uses a wider concept. Interest coalitions may—or may not—act in a coordinated way over time to pursue their goals, acknowledging that political influence is limited to coordinated action. For example, journalists and academics may influence politics without necessarily interacting with specific interest groups on a regular basis over time.

5. The “Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa” (AGRA) is chaired by Kofi A. Annan, the former Secretary-General of the United Nations. See <http://www.agra-alliance.org/>.

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